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Companions, Prequels, and Side Stories: Why Bother?

Essay



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Companions, Prequels, and Side Stories: Why Bother?

There's a thought that Circles around the internet like wildfire every few months. Why a prequel, why a spin-off, why? why? why? why? why? My response to that is. Why are you complaining about more stuff, look if it's bad that's a different conversation, but why not. Sometimes a creator wants to make a side story exploring a character they like, sometimes they want a prequel to fill in the backstory of the world. So why does it matter to you?

Some creators write a book series and then later go back and think, *'hey what if I made a story featuring Bob (as an example) he's a fun character and I could do something with him.'* They may not have initially planned to do so but nonetheless they want to. So why are you trying to Inhibit their creativity? Was that not what you liked?

Personally I already know that I have several of this "Side quests" I wish to write, some are prequels, others are books explore a single character, others still just fun stories I want to write because I can.

Should I have to justify myself to you if I want to do this? No i shouldn't. But let me do that for you anyway.

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The Benefits of Companions, Prequels and Side stories

Sorry about that dear reader, that was a bit intense... Back to cheery CJ we go.

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Prequels.

Lets start with Prequels since they are often the most lamented.

Prequels by their very nature are strange because most of the time the reader is aware of what is going to happen. For an example I always point to the star wars films. If you watch them in the order they were released (Ahrrm, The correct order) You already know Anakin falls to the dark side and becomes Darth Vader before you even meet Anakin properly in the prequels. But does that make the prequels and projects like the clone wars worse. Not in my opinion. (What did that was nobody checking Georges scripts but I digress.) What the prequel films and especially the clone wars did however was make us care about Anakin more, so that every time we rewatch the original trilogy we can understand more deeply why Luke is so insistent on saving his father and the deep sadness of his death. Because

we have come to love Anakin through watching his growth from little boy on Tatooine, through his Jedi training, then watching his exploits as a respected formidable general and combatant in the clone wars. It makes the fall from grace all the more impactful and the eventual redemption emotionally resonant.

Prequels are there to add extra detail and emotion to the existing material. Further they can be used to explore times in a worlds history that are only alluded to in the main text. I can personally attest to this as In my first book I made reference to an event in my worlds history, and as I was writing that I thought, that's actually a story all on its own that deserves to be told.

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Companions.

On to Companions. Shall I explain what I mean by companions first? Probably.

Essentially what I mean when I say companion is a book that provides Extra content to a preexisting narrative, without said content being necessary to understand the narrative. I guess an example of this would be the appendices of Tolkien, specifically the ones which detail what Gandalf was doing during the events of the hobbit. They add detail. They flesh out the world. They give us information about characters and events that aren't essential to Bilbo's adventure.

And that's precisely why they work as companion material. You don't need to know all of it to understand *The Hobbit*, but if you are interested in the deeper story of Middle-earth, it is

there for you.

And that's the key distinction I believe. Companion materials should enhance the experience, not hold the main story hostage. This is why in my opinion that material detailing Gandalf's path, felt somewhat cumbersome when it was shoved into the hobbit films. (I like those films by the way.) But there is a big difference between. "Here is some extra lore if you're interested." and "You need to sit through all this extra lore that ultimately does nothing of note for the main story before we can get back to Bilbo." Now If they had made that content its own film, that I would not have minded.

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Side stories...

Wait didn't I just do that. No.

Side stories at least in my definition, are stories that don't relate to the main plot what so ever, they are simply a cool story that may happen to be going on at the same time.

Maybe it follows a character who appears in the main story.

Maybe it follows someone who never appears at all.

Maybe it takes place on the other side of the world while the main characters are off doing whatever the hell they're doing. The important thing is that the story doesn't need to connect to the main plot in order to justify its own existence. It can simply exist because the author wants to write it, because they feel it is a story worth telling. And honestly sometimes that's enough.

Not every story needs to advance the grand narrative. Not Every character needs to be secretly connected to the villain.

Sometimes you can just tell a story because you like the character, or to explore a corner of your world that you think would be interesting. Sometimes you can write something completely ridiculous because you thought of it at two in the morning and thought, *'You know what? That would actually be really funny.'*

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And that's something that I think has been lost in the modern world. The fact that creative works... **Are creative works.** The creator is allowed to create. Now if the prequel is bad, criticise the prequel. If a spin-off is bad, criticise the spin-off

If companion material is bloated or gets in the way of the pre-existing main story critique that. But I will never understand the argument that a creator shouldn't make something purely because its unnecessary. When did something being necessary make it good, when did something being unnecessary make it bad. Because that is the argument that some people online spout isn't it. Was the lord of the rings necessary. Would the world have ended if it had never been published. I think not. But it is widely known as the birth of modern fiction.

So essentially what I'm saying is simply because something isn't needed don't hate on it for existing, read it or watch it and if it's bad critique it. But let people create.

Thank you for reading.

CJ Philip

